

SPOILER-FREE PREVIEW

A family story under pressure.

Read an opening scene and one genuine exhibit from the expanded narrative edition. This preview contains no solution or hidden identity disclosure.

Inside the complete game: a sustained character story, an archive of inspectable records, working pages, progressive hints, an evidence-cited solution, and an expanded aftermath.

Play alone or investigate together. Every required clue is in the supplied papers. Print in grayscale or use the PDF bookmarks and catalog. No host or outside research is needed.

Player file: 29 pages. Preview pages are selected excerpts; their archive and story labels match the full edition.

THE STORY CONTINUES

The unused cup

Before the opening brief

Daniel Wren put out two cups before remembering that he needed one. He left the second on the table. Taking it back to the shelf had become a small correction he could not always bear to make.

The letter from Veyr occupied Margaret's place.

He had read his own name in it several times. Daniel Wren, retired railway clerk. A man whose days had become quiet enough that the arrival of any post gave them a shape. The letter described a place in a succession. It did not offer the simple explanation for his life that he found himself wanting from it.

When Orme presented his declaration, Daniel listened longer than he might have listened to another man. Orme spoke as though there were still important tasks for him to perform, and as though experience at a railway desk might prepare him to do them well.

"You are accustomed to responsibility," Orme said.

Daniel looked at the two cups. "Some kinds."

Orme did not ask about the second. He put the paper where Daniel could sign it.

There was comfort in being given a line to complete. Daniel had spent a working life understanding which forms had to precede which decisions. The private declaration looked like another gate a sensible man should pass through without making trouble.

He reached for the pen, then drew the official letter nearer instead. Its warning about agents and authority was less flattering than Orme's account of him. It also had a seal and a reference he could check.

"I should like to read the earlier papers."

"Of course. There is the deadline to consider."

Daniel felt the pressure at once: asking to understand could be made to sound like refusing to act. He had not expected the possibility of a crown to resemble an awkward afternoon over a form.

"Then I ought to begin reading," he said.

Orme waited. Daniel had to resist filling the silence with an apology.

The second cup remained on the table after the papers were opened. Daniel could not ask Margaret whether the news would have amused or troubled her. He could look at the records of both families and refuse, for the moment, to let a stranger decide which of them mattered.

The royal notice

18 April 1928

Veyrian Legation / dispatch V-228 / signed M. Sorel

Addressee	Mr Daniel Wren, 18 Nettle Street, Elmsreach
Subject	Collateral succession under the Settlement of 1872
Position reported	Second in the present provisional order
Reason for contact	Identification and documentary confirmation
Response deadline	30 April 1928
Official signatory	Marta Sorel, Legation Secretary

The death of Queen Adelise without a surviving descendant brings the collateral remainder into operation. The registered search presently places you second. Your present surname does not by itself defeat a claim. Neither this notice nor an agent's enclosure installs a sovereign.

Please return through the Legation any relevant birth, marriage or family correspondence. You may verify this dispatch independently by its number. Mr Julian Orme is a private representative; his forms are not themselves instruments of the Crown.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)